

Pretérito Indefinido vs Pretérito Imperfecto

Quick guide for **British English** speakers — with mental hooks, tables and practical examples.

1. Central distinction

Indefinido	Imperfecto
Completed action — has a clear beginning and end	Ongoing / unfinished action — no defined limit
"It happened and it's done"	"It was happening, but we don't know if it finished"
The result is visible	The context / scene is described

GB Mental hook: Think of a **checklist tick**  (indefinido) vs a **scene unfolding**  (imperfecto).

2. Mental hooks for Brits

The "I was ___ing WHEN ___ happened" structure

The star combination of spoken British English:

British English	Spanish
I was walking to the pub WHEN I saw Dave	Caminaba hacia el pub CUANDO vi a Dave
I was having a cuppa WHEN the phone rang	Tomaba un té CUANDO sonó el teléfono
We were queuing WHEN it started pissing down	Hacíamos cola CUANDO empezó a llover a cántaros

🔑 **Golden rule:** The *was/were* ___ing → **Imperfecto**. The ___ed / *happened* → **Indefinido**.

3. Trigger words

Indefinido (punctual action)	Imperfecto (habitual / ongoing action)
ayer — yesterday	mientras — while / whilst
anoche — last night	antes — before (used to)
de repente — suddenly	cuando era niño/a — when I was a child
una vez — once	todos los días — every day (past routine)
el otro día — the other day	siempre — always (past habit)
el año pasado — last year	nunca — never (past habit)
esta mañana (finished)	a menudo — often (past)
aquella tarde (specific)	cada verano — each summer

⚠️ Watch out: **mientras** can take both if there are two ongoing actions: "*Mientras **cantaba, bailaba***" (two imperfectos).

4. The metaphor: Photo vs Film 📷 🎬

Indefinido = PHOTO 📷	Imperfecto = FILM 🎬
Captures a specific moment	Shows a moving scene
"I came, I saw, I conquered" (Julius Caesar)	"The sun was shining, people were laughing..."
Focuses on the action	Focuses on the atmosphere
One click and it's done	Background of the story

Example:

📷 "***Entré** en el pub, **pedí** una pinta y **saludé** a Dave.*" (photos → indefinido)

📺 "El pub **estaba** lleno, **sonaba** música de los 90 y la gente **bailaba**." (scene → imperfecto)

5. Comparative table with English clues

Context	Spanish	British English	Tense
Completed action	Compré el periódico	I bought the newspaper	Indefinido ✅
Past habitual action	Compraba el periódico cada día	I used to buy / would buy the paper every day	Imperfecto 🔄
Description / background	El cielo estaba gris	The sky was grey	Imperfecto 🌫️
Punctual event interrupting	Sonó el teléfono	The phone rang	Indefinido 🔔
Ongoing action	Leía el <i>Guardian</i>	I was reading the <i>Guardian</i>	Imperfecto 📖
State / emotion (no limit)	Quería ir al pub	I wanted to go to the pub	Imperfecto 😞
Sudden change of state	Se enfadó	He got angry (sudden change)	Indefinido 😡💥

6. The star combination: Imperfecto + Indefinido

This is the most important narrative structure in Spanish. The **Imperfecto** sets the scene; the **Indefinido** delivers the main action.

Formula:

Imperfecto (scene / what was happening) → **CUANDO** → **Indefinido** (what happened)

Everyday examples:

Spanish	Mental translation (EN-UK)
Tomaba un café cuando entró mi jefe	I was having a coffee when my boss walked in
Conducía por la M25 cuando se pinchó la rueda	I was driving on the M25 when I got a puncture
Veía la tele cuando cortaron la luz	I was watching telly when the power went out
Charlábamos en la puerta del pub cuando empezó a llover	We were chatting outside the pub when it started raining
Esperaba el bus cuando vi a un viejo amigo	I was waiting for the bus when I saw an old mate

More examples (Spanish only):

- Sonaba** el despertador, pero yo **seguía** durmiendo. De repente, **recordé** que **tenía** una reunión importante y **salté** de la cama.
- Vivía** en un piso diminuto en Londres. Un día **decidí** mudarme al campo y **alquilé** una casa con jardín.

- **Siempre jugaba** al fútbol los sábados, pero aquel sábado **llovió** tanto que **cancelaron** el partido.

Visual Summary

[Sum-up Chart](#)

PAST IN SPANISH	
INDEFINIDO	IMPERFECTO
PHOTO 📷	FILM 🎬
Tick ✅	Scene 🌊
What HAPPENED	How it WAS
Action	Description
New	Background / Habit

↓
Imperfecto + cuando + Indefinido
= The star combination ⭐

🧠 Remember: If you can put "**I was ___ing**" or "**used to**" → **Imperfecto**. If you can put "**I ___ed (and it's done)**" → **Indefinido**.

🏆 Practice exercises — Indefinido or Imperfecto?

Practice 1 — Central distinction

Complete with the correct tense. Remember: Indefinido = completed action ✅ | Imperfecto = ongoing action / without limit 🌊

1. Ayer ____ (ir) al pub con mis colegas y ____ (pedir) una ronda de pintas.

"Fui" and "pedí" are Indefinido because "ayer" marks a completed time period. Both actions have a clear beginning and end: they happened and they're done.

2. De pequeña, ____ (vivir) en un pueblo cerca de Londres y ____ (ir) a un colegio muy pequeño.

"Vivía" and "iba" are Imperfecto because they describe situations in the past without a defined limit. We don't know when they started or ended: they are the background scene.

3. El otro día ____ (perder) el tren de las 8:15 y ____ (llegar) tarde al trabajo.

"Perdí" and "llegué" are Indefinido because they are punctual, completed actions. "El otro día" points to a specific moment in the past.

Practice 2 — Mental hooks for Brits

Use the "I was ___ing WHEN ___ happened" structure: the was/were -ing → Imperfecto; the ___ed → Indefinido.

4. ____ (caminar) hacia la parada del bus CUANDO ____ (ver) un accidente de tráfico.

"Caminaba" is Imperfecto (ongoing action = "I **was walking**"). "Vi" is Indefinido (punctual action = "I **saw**").

5. ____ (tomar) una pinta tranquilamente en el pub CUANDO ____ (entrar) mi excompañero de piso.

"Tomaba" is Imperfecto because it describes the background scene ("I **was having** a pint"). "Entró" is Indefinido because it interrupts the action ("he **walked in**").

6. Nosotros ____ (hacer) cola para el concierto CUANDO ____ (empezar) a llover a cántaros.

"Hacíamos" is Imperfecto ("we **were queuing**"), "empezó" is Indefinido ("it **started**" — action that interrupts).

Practice 3 — Trigger words

Look at the clues: *ayer, de repente, una vez* → Indefinido. *Mientras, cuando era niño, todos los días* → Imperfecto.

7. ____ (llover) mucho mientras ____ (conducir) por la M25 el viernes pasado.

"Llovía" and "conducía" are Imperfecto because "mientras" indicates that both actions were in progress at the same time.

8. De repente, el tren ____ (pararse) y todas las luces ____ (apagarse).

"Se paró" and "se apagaron" are Indefinido because "de repente" indicates sudden, punctual actions.

9. Cuando ____ (ser) niño, ____ (jugar) al fútbol en el parque todos los sábados.

"Era" is Imperfecto because "cuando era niño" places the action in a period without a clear limit. "Jugaba" is also Imperfecto because "todos los sábados" indicates a habitual routine.

Practice 4 — Photo vs Film 📷 🎬

Indefinido = PHOTO (concrete action, one click) | Imperfecto = FILM (scene, atmosphere, background)

10. La fiesta de anoche ____ (ser) increíble. ____ (haber) música en directo y todo el mundo ____ (bailar).

"Era", "había" and "bailaba" are all Imperfecto because they describe the atmosphere of the party — the background FILM.

11. ____ (entrar) en la tienda, ____ (coger) el periódico y ____ (pagar) en la caja.

"Entré", "cogí" and "pagué" are Indefinido — completed actions one after another, like three PHOTOS in sequence.

12. El cielo ____ (estar) gris y ____ (llover) ligeramente cuando ____ (salir) de casa.

"Estaba" and "llovía" are Imperfecto — they paint the landscape (FILM). "Salí" is Indefinido — punctual action (PHOTO).

Practice 5 — Comparative table with English clues

Translate it mentally: "used to" / "was ___ing" → Imperfecto. "___ed (and it's done)" → Indefinido.

13. Cuando ____ (vivir) en Mánchester, ____ (comprar) el Guardian cada mañana.

"Vivía" and "compraba" are Imperfecto because they express a situation and a habitual routine — in English it would be "I **used to live**" / "I **used to buy**".

14. El sábado pasado ____ (comprar) un billete de lotería, pero no ____ (ganar) nada.

"Compré" and "gané" are *Indefinido* — completed actions at a specific moment. In English: "I **bought**" / "I **didn't win**" (and it's done).

15. Mi hermana _____ (querer) mudarse a Edimburgo, pero al final _____ (decidir) quedarse en Londres.

"Quería" is *Imperfecto* because it expresses a desire without a time limit ("she **wanted**", but we don't know if she still does). "Decidió" is *Indefinido* — punctual change of state ("she **decided**").

Practice 6 — The star combination: Imperfecto + Indefinido

Imperfecto = the setting / what was happening. *Indefinido* = what happened (often with "cuando" or "de repente").

16. _____ (leer) un libro en el tren cuando _____ (sonar) mi móvil.

"Leía" is *Imperfecto* (ongoing action — the background). "Sonó" is *Indefinido* (action that interrupts — the foreground).

17. _____ (esperar) el Tube en la estación de Oxford Circus cuando de repente _____ (oír) un anuncio por los altavoces.

"Esperaba" is *Imperfecto* (background scene = "I **was waiting**"). "Oí" is *Indefinido* (punctual action = "I **heard**").

18. Nosotros _____ (charlar) en la puerta del pub cuando _____ (ver) a un actor famoso.

"Charlábamos" is *Imperfecto* (ongoing action = "we **were chatting**"). "Vimos" is *Indefinido* (concrete action that interrupts = "we **saw**").